Territorial issues figured prominently in the Sino-Soviet dispute since 1960, and Deng Xiaoping and Mikhail Gorbachev pledged to ‘close the past and open the future’ in their 1989 summit meeting to normalize relations between the two countries (Wishnick 2001: 87–101). However, the disputes were kept continued between the two countries. Further, territorial, political, economic, financial, trade, and many other issues caused the relationship between the two countries.

The new Russian Federation foreign policymakers gave a prominent position to its Eastern Policy. In February 1992, the New Russian Federation signed a border treaty with China. But, the then President of Russia, Boris Yeltsin, and Foreign Minister Kozyrev remained wary of China. They thought that China was too anti-Western and critical of Russia’s democratic development (Tsigankov 2009). Thus, Russian leaders and politicians generally abstained from meetings with Chinese officials during that time. Yet, in March 1992, Kozyrev traveled to China to stimulate economic development between the two nations. The trip lasted for only thirty hours, and both the countries disagreed on human rights issues. Again, Yeltsin visited China in December of the same year (1992) to bring back the lost trade ties between the two countries; however, this trip remained futile (ibid.). Thus, relations between the two countries were kept under the mat until the mid-1990s, despite both countries’ efforts.

However, when Russia’s foreign policy started fundamentally changing from 1996 onwards, Yevgeni Primakov aimed to improve Russia’s relative power position globally and sought to build multipolarity as a desirable aim with like-minded nations (Tsigankov 2009). In 1996 on January 24, at the Foreign Ministry’s Council on Foreign Economic relations, Primakov put forward four features to Russia’s foreign policy in the upcoming period. They are:

- The territorial integrity of the new Russian Federation.
- Support for Centripetal Tendencies within the former Soviet Union.
- Stabilization of International Relations, particularly on a regional level.
- Non-proliferation of weapons of mass destruction and prevention of destabilization developments (Kratochvil 2002; Weydenthal 1996).

In improving relations with Russia, on April 24, 1997, the then Chinese president Jiang Zemin visited Russia to sign an agreement between five Central Asian Republics and China for a mutual reduction in military forces